



Breathing Guide

Gentle visual practices to explore at your own comfortable pace

Try a gentle breathing pattern, then keep only the pace that feels comfortable and steady.

Breathing Guide

Teens, adults, caregivers, educators and beginners

Comfort first

Breathing exercises are optional. Begin by noticing your ordinary breath without changing it. If counting or pauses feel uncomfortable, return to natural breathing. A smaller, easier breath is always okay.

How to use this tool

Work through the pages in any order. Use a pen, pencil, or digital annotation tool. Keep what helps; leave what does not.

Important

Never force deep breathing or breath-holding. Stop for dizziness, pain, panic, or shortness of breath and follow medical advice for respiratory or other health conditions. If symptoms are severe, sudden, or life-threatening, contact emergency services now.

Six gentle ways to practice

Notice first

For 30 seconds, observe breathing as it is: fast, slow, shallow, deep, or mixed.

Comfortable count

Inhale gently for 2 to 4 counts; exhale gently for 2 to 4 counts. Repeat five rounds.

Longer exhale

Inhale comfortably for 3. Exhale comfortably for 4 or 5. Return to normal breathing if needed.

Finger-trace breath

Trace up a finger while inhaling; trace down while exhaling. Move across five fingers.

Square option

If pauses feel comfortable: inhale 4, pause 4, exhale 4, pause 4. Stop at any time.

Sigh and reset

Take an ordinary inhale followed by a slow, unforced exhale. Repeat three times.

My one-minute breathing practice

Follow the lines at a pace that feels comfortable. Inhale gently, then exhale gently. You may ignore the count entirely.

INHALE**EXHALE****REST**

Repeat with a pace that feels natural. You can stop at any time.

Round 1: What I notice

Round 2: What I notice

Round 3: What I notice

Afterward: What felt comfortable?

Find your comfortable practice

Pattern I tried

Before: body feeling / stress level (0-10)

After: body feeling / stress level (0-10)

What felt comfortable?

What would I change next time?

My exit plan

It is okay to stop a practice. Decide what you will do if it does not feel supportive.

A sign this practice is not working for me

My adjustment: breathe normally / change position / take a break / contact support

One setting where I can practice safely

Sources and use note

This printable tool was designed with general self-care and coping concepts from the sources below. It is educational material, not health care or therapy.

National Institute of Mental Health: Caring for Your Mental Health

Self-care, connection, stress-management framing

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/caring-for-your-mental-health>

National Institute of Mental Health: So Stressed Out

Journaling, relaxation, mindfulness, sleep, and support concepts

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/so-stressed-out-fact-sheet>

NHS: Breathing exercises for stress

Comfortable, unforced breathing guidance

<https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/guides-tools-and-activities/breathing-exercises-for-stress/>

WebMD: What Is Box Breathing?

Optional paced-breathing presentation

<https://www.webmd.com/balance/what-is-box-breathing>

WebMD: Quick Stress-Relief Rituals

Sensory grounding context

<https://www.webmd.com/depression/quick-stress-relief-rituals>

American Psychological Association: Stress management tips

Thought, emotion, behavior, and reframing context

<https://www.apa.org/topics/stress/tips>

CASEL: Fundamentals of SEL

Emotion identification and self-management framing

<https://casel.org/fundamentals-of-sel/>

CDC: Information for Family Caregivers

Caregiver capacity, breaks, and support framing

<https://www.cdc.gov/disability-and-health/about/information-for-family-caregivers.html>

Child Mind Institute: How to Help Children Calm Down

Coping-ahead and child-friendly calming support

<https://childmind.org/article/how-to-help-children-calm-down/>

Wikipedia: Mindfulness

Plain-language background only; not clinical authority

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mindfulness>

Reddit community discussions

User-centered presentation inspiration only; not clinical authority

https://www.reddit.com/r/Anxiety/comments/1ch67c8/making_an_anxiety_tool_box_what_should_i_put_in_it/

YouTube guided box-breathing example

Visual pacing inspiration only; not clinical authority

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tEmt1Znux58>